

A Study on the Rhythmic Beauty of Assamese Folk Percussion Instruments Used in Devotional Folk Song

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Abstract

*The precise presentation of music makes the path of attaining **Moksha** accessible. Music is primarily the attainment of all the Goals of human life. (Chari Purusharthas) viz: Dharma, Artha, Kama and Moksha. Music, dance and instruments have been prevailing among the humans since the time they could be able to feel fear, anxiety, hunger, thirst, love, affection etc. Musical instruments are one of the primary components of music creation. The music and dance could not be considered complete without the use of musical instruments. All the four types of instruments viz: Tata, Avanaddha, Ghana and Sushira with their individual characteristics play significant role in the creation of music. Tata and Sushira instruments conserve the tune of music, on the other hand Avanaddha and Ghana instruments maintain the rhythm of music.*

The primary objective of this research work is to study the folk musical instruments of Assam which are related with Assamese devotional folk songs.

The research paper is completed through the descriptive and analytical methods with the help of primary and secondary sources and APA referencing style is followed.

Keyword: Assam, Instrument, Devotion, Folk, Song

1.0 Introduction: -

The great saint and reformer Srimanta Sankaradeva played a vital role in reorganizing the Assamese society. By introducing the Neo-Vaishnavite movement, he laid the foundation for the society to be united under the values of devotion, equality and moral discipline. Unlike ritual-based religion, Sankaradeva's philosophy centred around one supreme God, devotion (*bhakti*), and a life of moral purity. (Bayan, 2016, p. 88)

The author Bhabajit Bayan has discussed in detail the devotional ideals and creations of Sankaradeva through his book '*Xarba Bharatiya Vakti Andolan Aru Sankar Devar Kirtan Ghosa.*' The songs, dramas, dances, and other literary and artistic creations of Sankaradeva and his followers carried religious as well as social messages. Through *Bargeet* (devotional songs), *Ankiya Naat* (drama), *Ojapali* (folk performance style), and other literary works, Sankaradeva spread his teachings among the masses.

His efforts gave birth to a new cultural identity of the Assamese people. The Neo-Vaishnavite movement not only redefined religious practices but also created a new social structure based on unity, equality and devotion. This movement contributed immensely to the cultural integration and moral foundation of the Assamese society.

Loka Sangeet i.e. folk music is a medium to express the emotions and feelings of the rural masses. *Loka* means the folk masses and *Sangeet* i.e. the compilation of music, dance and instruments, which means the music that has been prevailing orally among the folk masses in the villages is called *Loka sangeet* (folk music) where the emotions and feelings of the rural masses were incorporated.

1.1 Literature review: -

1. Hazarika, P. (2017). '*TOKARI GEET*'. In this book the author presents a detailed analysis of *Tokari geet* and their accompanying instruments.
2. Mahanta, Monik Chandra (2007) '*ANAND LAHARI*' in this book the author critically analyses the aesthetic perspective of the collection of devotion folk songs of Assam. The author discusses various compositions of Assamese folk songs such as *Diha Naam*, *Tokari geet*, *Dehabisar Geet*, *Kamrupi Lokageet* etc., and explains their social relevance in detail.
3. Gogoi, Kamala (2022) "Axomor Diha Naam". The article is found in the book chapter namely "*INDRAPASTHA*". In the article the author explains the spiritualism of Diha Naam, origin and evolution. His discussion has been presented with much clarity and depth.
4. Mahanta, Golap (2013) '*KHOL ANKA*' is discussing about the origin of instrument Khol. In this book, the author presents various tala of Sankari tradition, Bols, Sahini etc. in detail.
5. Duarah, D. (2009). '*ASOMAR BADIYAJANTRA*', is discussing about the origin of Indian Music, music of Assam, various musical instruments of Assam along with discussions on the musical instruments of various ethnic group of Assam.
6. Dutta, Dr. Birandranath. (2017) '*ASAMIYA SANGITAR AITIHYA*' (Translated by D. K. Kalita, 2021), '*Heritage of Assamese Music*' is discussing about the Assamese music from a historical perspective i.e. its evolution into modernity. Dr. Dilip Kumar Kalita translated and published the book in English in 2021 under the title Heritage of Assamese Music.

2.0 Musical instrument of Assam:

Any object that is being developed by humans to create melodious sounds which could be utilized in music is called a musical instrument i.e. anything that is played in music to

conserve the aesthetics of music by maintaining the tune, rhythm and tempo is a musical instrument.

“We hear different types of sounds from different mediums in the natural environment around us. For example, the roar of clouds, lightning, the sound of rivers, the sound of rain, the sound of wind, the rustling of dry leaves, the sounds of animals and birds. By imitating these sounds, people try to make the sound in different ways through different mediums.”
(Saikia G. , 2024, p. 117)

The practice of playing the musical instruments as one the significant component in musical practices has been in prevalence in Assam too like the different regions in India. The proofs of modes and practices of music in Assam are found in the resources gathered from ancient temples, monasteries, stone inscriptions, palm-leaf manuscripts, sculptures, illustrated manuscripts, religious scriptures as well as the treatises on music and the history books. (Duarah D. , 2009, p. 32) In the book ‘*Asomor Badyajantra*’, the author Dharmeswar Duarah has provided a comprehensive and detailed discussion on this topic.

Various folk songs that have been performed in the festivals celebrated among different ethnicities and tribes of Assam are- *Biya naam, Aai naam, Bihu naam, Kamrupi Lokageet, Goalporiya Lokageer, Zikir-Jari, Dehbisar Geet, Tokari Geet, Dihanaam, Naukheldar Geet, Mohoho Geet* etc. Some *Tata vadya* (chordophones) of Assam are- *Tokari, Dotara, Been, Charinda, Lao-Tokari* or *Ektara* and *Ananda Lahari*. These instruments with their own distinct characteristics are being used with various folk songs to conserve the melody and tunes of the songs. Various *Avanaddha vadya* (membranophones) such as *Khol, Dhol, Nagara, Dagar* etc... are also accompanied with these songs. These instruments, with their unique characteristics, help in maintaining the rhythm and tempo of the folk songs.

2.1 Avanaddha Vadya

(a) Nagara

Nagara is a primary percussion instrument which is used in devotional folk songs of Assam. It is made by shaping clay into a hollow shell and covering it with a thin layer of dead animal skin. The body of the instrument is semi-spherical in shape with gradually narrowing from the top to the bottom. The hollow portion is covered with dead animal skin, tightly stretched and fastened with *Boroti*.

It is usually played in pairs, struck with two sticks. Among the two Nagara, one is larger and the other one is smaller. In different regions of Lower Assam, the smaller Nagara is popularly known as *Kurkuri*. (Duarah D. , 2009, pp. 61-62) The larger Nagara produces low-frequency sounds, while the smaller one produces mid-frequency sounds.

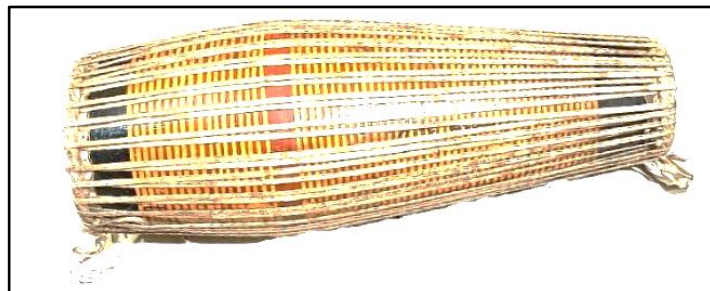


In Assamese culture, Nagara is used as an accompanying instrument in various folk performances such as *Diha Naam*, *Tokari Geet*, *Dehbichar Geet*, *Nagara Naam*, etc. The author Dharmaswar Duarah mentioned in his book ‘Asomor Badyajantra’ that- In the mythological literature of Assam, the instrument Nagara is mentioned. In the broader corpus of Indian literature such as the Ramayana, Mahabharata, and various Puranas, this same instrument is referred to as ‘*Dundubhi*’.

(b) Khol

In the cultural history of Assam, one of the most significant contributions of Srimanta Sankardeva was the introduction of the Khol, which played a pivotal role in initiating a spiritual and cultural awakening based on the ideas of Vaishnavism. The Khol is a traditional percussion instrument. It is a primary percussion instrument of *Bhaona*, *Bargeet*, *Sattriya Nritya*, and other forms of Sattriya or Sankari music.

Sankardeva himself provided the measurements and instructed Jagannath Kumar of *Kapili Mukh* to construct the shape of Khol with clay. After that, they are covered with animal skins at both ends of the shell by *Halamara Muchiya* and produce a sweet rhythmic sound. The instrument Khol is thus regarded as one of Sankardeva’s immortal creations. (Saikia G. , 2017, p. 19)



Although the Khol is recognized as an independent instrument, the rhythmic patterns of khol are played following the instrument of Nagara in devotional folk songs.

“Boluramor Aatoi Axiya Tekhone

Kholara Jukhaka Dila.

Troyudask Aangul Bamo Vage Jana

Dahine Na Aangul Koia” (Mahanta, 2013, p. 0.13)

(c) Dagar

The instrument ‘Dagar’ is one of the most ancient Avanaddha Vadya of Assamese folk music genres. It is made from the branches of Neem or Jackfruit tree. The instrument is circular in shape, and the size is small, open on both sides with a hollow middle part. One side is covered with the dry skin of a goat or Monitor lizard.

The playing style of the instrument Dagar is distinct from other Avanaddha Vadya. It is held in one hand, and the membrane is moved up and down with the middle finger, while the fingers of the other hand rub or strike it to produce a beautiful sound.

This instrument is found in different regions of India under various local names, showing its wide traditional presence and regional variations.

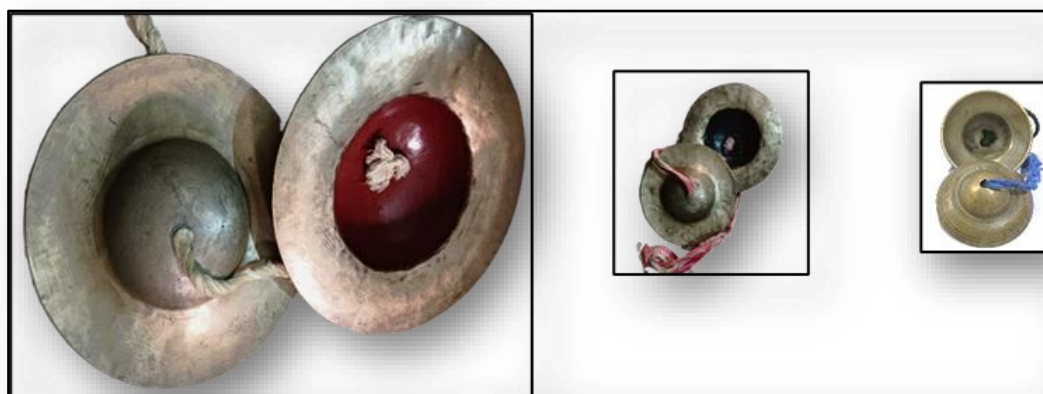


2.2 Ghana Vadya: -

(a) Taal

‘Taal’ is a type of *Ghana Vadya* (idiophonic instrument) made of metals such as bell-metal and brass. This instrument is essential for indicating rhythm and tempo in music. The Taal is made of bell-metal. In the musical tradition of Assam, several types of taal can be found, such as *Bor Taal*, *Pati Taal*, *Khuti Taal*, *Ram Taal*, *Bhur Taal*, *Kar Taal*, etc. Each of these has its own distinct musical characteristics.

2.3 Some characteristics of Avanaddha Vadya followed by the classification:



According to the classification of Avanaddha Vadya mentioned in the book ‘Bharatiya Sangeet Vadya’, authored by Dr. Lalmani Mishra the features of the above avanaddha vadya are explained below:

NAGARA:

From the perspective of Making:

1. The Nagara is half-spherical in shape, hollow inside, and has only one playing surface.
2. It is usually made of clay, and the open side is covered with animal skin.

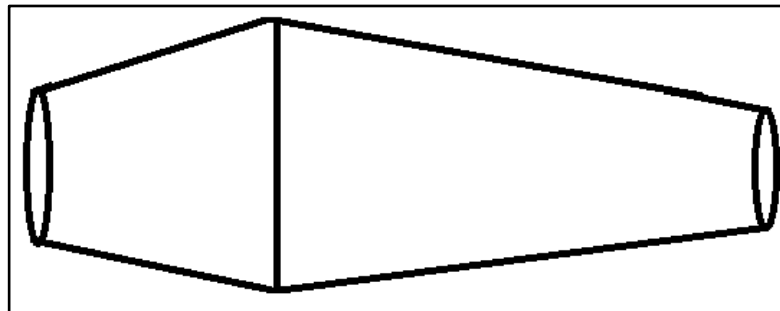
From the perspective of Playing:

1. For performance, the Nagara is placed upright on a stable surface above a circular support namely Biriya or Gher, with its playing head facing upward.
2. It is played by two thin sticks.
3. A pair of Nagara includes two Nagaras, one is small and another slightly bigger.
4. The bigger part produces low frequency sound, while the smaller one produces high-frequency sound.

KHOL:

From the perspective of Making:

1. This instrument is made of jackfruit wood and cham wood, and it is a double-headed drum with a hollow middle section.
2. Both ends of the drum are covered with animal skin.
3. There are two ends of the *Khola* or *Dima*, one is larger and the other is smaller.
4. The middle part of the drum is constructed with about $\frac{1}{3}$ of the central part raised.



5. On the animal skin which is attached on the two ends of the instrument, an adhesive substance made from iron powders and rice paste is applied as a coating.

From the perspective of Playing:

1. The Khol is played with the palms and fingers of both hands.
2. During accompaniment with songs, dances, and dramatic performances, the instrument is held on the lap while playing.



3. In *Gayan-Bayan*, that is, during the preliminary ritual performance, it is played while performing dance movements.



3.0 Discussions: -

1. For the convenience of discussion, a few examples of the rhythmic phrases (*Bols*) of Nagara, Khol, and Dagar in different rhythmic patterns (*tala*) and time signature are presented below: -

- **Rhythmic pattern:**

(A) KAHARBA TAAL: -This *tala* consists of 8 matras divided into two Bibhagas. The *chanda* of this *tala* is widely used in various musical forms of Assam.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
DHA	GE	NA	TI	NA	KA	DHI	NA
X				O			

The total matras of Kaharba taal can be compared with the 4/4-time signature of western music. On the instrument Dagar, it is played in two cycles of the 8-matra Kaharba *tala*. The *bols* of the Kaharba *tala*, as played on instruments such as the Dagar, Nagara, and Khol are as follows: -

a. Dagar: -

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
DHIN	- N	TA	DHIN	- N	DHIN	TA	- AK
X				O			
TIT	TI	TA	DHIN	- N	DHIN	TA	- AK
X				O			

b. Nagara: -

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
DHIN	--	KU	RU	TA	- AK	DHI	NA
<i>X</i>				<i>O</i>			
DHI	- IN	--	--	KHIR	KHIT	TA	- AK
<i>X</i>				<i>O</i>			

c. Khol: -

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
JID	--	DHE	NI	TA	- AK	DHI	NA
<i>X</i>				<i>O</i>			
DHI	- IN	--	--	KHIR	KHIT	TA	- AK
<i>X</i>				<i>O</i>			

(B) KHEMTA TAAL: The total number of *matras* of Khemta tala is 12 which are divided into four *Bibhaga*. The total matras of Khemta taal can be compared with the 6/8-time signature of western music

1	2	3	4	5	6
DHA	TE	TE	NA	TE	TE
<i>X</i>			2		
7	8	9	10	11	12
TA	TE	TE	NA	DHI	NA
<i>O</i>			3		

a. Dagar: -

1	2	3	4	5	6
DHIN	- N	DHI	NA	DHI	- N
<i>X</i>			2		
7	8	9	10	11	12
TA	- TA	DHI	NA	DHI	- N
<i>O</i>			3		

b. Nagara: -

i. (Madhya Laya)

1	2	3	4	5	6
DHIN	KURU	KURU	TA	KHI	TI
<i>X</i>			2		
7	8	9	10	11	12
TA	- AK	DHI	NA	DHI	NA
<i>O</i>			3		

ii. (Drut Laya)

1	2	3	4	5	6
DHIN	KURU	KHIT	TAK	DHI	NA
<i>X</i>			2		
7	8	9	10	11	12
DHIN	KURU	KHIT	TAK	DHI	NA
<i>O</i>			3		

BIJOY OR BIKHAM TAAL: -

This tala holds a distinctive position as compared to other talas. The Bijoy or Bikham tala consists of ten matras, which are organized into four Bibhagas. The first Bibhaga contains three matras, the second contains two matras, the third contains three matras, and the fourth contains two matras. It has been transmitted through oral tradition within Assamese music. Although it is rarely documented in classical musical texts, it is discussed in '*Taal Manikut*' by Paban Bordoloi, who mentions its prevalence in the folk songs of North-East India. The use of this tala is especially seen in the folk songs of Assam. (Bordoloi, 2014, p. 109)

Some musicians suggest that this tala is referred to as Bikham tala because its matras are considered Bikham Matrik. Many Assamese folk songs, such as Zikir-Jari, Kamrupi Lokageet, and Bihu Naam are traditionally performed in this tala.

The manner in which Bikham tala is played on different Avanaddha Vadya is discussed below. The total matras of Bijoy or Bikham taal can be compared with the 5/8-time signature of western music.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
DHA	DHI	-	NA	-	DHA	TI	-	NA	-
X			2		O			3	

a. Dagar: -

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
DHIN	DHI	- N	NA	-	TA	DHI	- N	NA	-
X			2		O			3	

DADRA TAAL: -

The total number of *matras* in Dadra talas is 6. The number of Bibhag of this tala is two and one bibhag has three *matras* each. The total matras of Dadra taal can be compared with the 3/4- time signature of western music

1	2	3	4	5	6
DHA	DHI	NA	DHA	TI	NA
X			O		

a. Dagar: -

1	2	3	4	5	6
DHIN	DHI DHI	NA	TA	DHI DHI	NA
X			O		

2. The Khol is an independent percussion instrument, and therefore it has its own specific rhythmic patterns (tala), which are entirely codified and mathematically structured.
3. The practice and teaching of Khol playing have been preserved in the satra institutions through the guru–sisya parampara (teacher–disciple tradition) since the Shankari era.
4. The main talas of the Khol show certain similarities with Hindustani and Carnatic rhythmic systems:
5. With Hindustani tala, similarities are found in the cycle (Avartan) and tempo variations (laykari), though the names of the tala are different.
6. With Carnatic tala, the classification of Jati bheda and Gati bheda shows considerable resemblance with the tala of the Khol.
7. The main percussion instruments of devotional folk songs of Assam are Nagera and Dagar.
8. Nagera is used in Tokari geet, Dehbichar geet, Diha naam, Thio naam, Nagera naam, etc.
9. Dagar is used in Deh-bichaar geet, Zikir, and Kamarupi folk songs.
10. In Assamese devotional folk songs, in order to imitate the playing of the Nagera, some distinct variations are adopted in the playing of the Khol.

4.0 Conclusion: -

Music is an integral part of human life. Literature, music, dance, drama, painting, and sculpture are the best expressions of human artistic creativity. Among these, music holds a very important place. Since ancient times, Assamese society has been enriched by music. From the era of Srimanta Sankardeva, music has been a major element in shaping the social and cultural consciousness of Assam.

In the modern age, Assamese music continues to uphold its importance by preserving traditional practices while embracing new forms. This blend of tradition and modernity has kept Assamese music vibrant. Scholars and researchers are continuing their efforts to explore Assamese music with various projects and academic research being carried out in this field as well.

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